

ATPL EASA STUDY GUIDE | 010 - AIR LAW

Chapter 3: Nationality & Registration Marks

Syllabus Source: CAE Oxford (pp. 59-66) | Pass Target: >= 90% AviationExam

1. LEGAL FOUNDATIONS: CHICAGO CONVENTION & ANNEX 7

Under Article 17 of the Chicago Convention, aircraft have the nationality of the State in which they are registered. Annex 7 specifies international standards for nationality and registration marks, placement, lettering dimensions, and identification plates.

- Dual Registration Prohibited (Art. 18): An aircraft cannot be validly registered in more than one State at the same time. However, registration may be transferred from one State to another.
- Domestic Law Governs (Art. 19): The registration or transfer of registration of aircraft in any Contracting State shall be made in accordance with its national laws and regulations.
- Display of Marks (Art. 20): Every aircraft engaged in international air navigation shall bear its appropriate nationality and registration marks.

2. STRUCTURE OF MARKS: NATIONALITY VS REGISTRATION

- Nationality Mark: Selected from the series of nationality symbols included in the radio call signs allocated to the State of Registry by the International Telecommunication Union (ITU). Examples: G = United Kingdom, F = France, D = Germany, EC = Spain, EI = Ireland, N = USA, HB = Switzerland, OO = Belgium, PH = Netherlands.
- Registration Mark: Consists of letters, numbers, or a combination assigned by the State of Registry or common mark registering authority.
- The Hyphen Rule: When the first character of the registration mark is a LETTER, it MUST be preceded by a HYPHEN (e.g. G-ABCD, EC-MNA, F-GZTA). In the USA, 'N' followed by numbers requires no hyphen (e.g. N12345).
- Common Mark: Assigned by ICAO to the common mark registering authority of an international operating agency (such as Arab Air Cargo). Preceded by a symbol assigned by ICAO.

3. LOCATION AND MINIMUM SIZING RULES (ANNEX 7)

Location on Aircraft	Position Specifics	Min. Height	Orientation & Spacing
Wings (Lower Surface)	Port (left) half of lower wing surface.	At least 30 cm (300 mm)	Tops of letters directed toward leading edge.
Fuselage / Vertical Tail	Each side of fuselage (between wings and tail) OR upper halves of vertical tail surfaces.	At least 30 cm (300 mm)	If multi-tail, displayed on outer sides of outer vertical fins.
Lighter-than-Air (Airships)	Tail surface or envelope.	At least 50 cm (500 mm)	Visible from ground and both sides.
Lighter-than-Air (Balloons)	Two places near maximum diameter on opposite sides.	At least 50 cm (500 mm)	Equatorial position.

Lettering Proportions & Typography Standards

- Letters must be capital letters in Roman characters without ornamentation. - Width of each character (except I and 1) shall be 2/3 of its height. - Thickness of lines (stroke) shall be 1/6 of the character height. - Spacing between characters shall not be less than 1/4 of a character width, nor more than 1/2 of character width.

4. THE AIRCRAFT IDENTIFICATION PLATE

Every aircraft engaged in international air navigation must carry an identification plate inscribed with its nationality mark and registration mark: - Material: Must be made of FIREPROOF METAL or other fireproof material of suitable physical properties. - Location: Secured in a prominent position NEAR THE MAIN ENTRANCE of the aircraft.

5. AVIATIONEXAM PRACTICE QUESTIONS (WITH EXPLANATIONS)

Q1: Can an aircraft be validly registered in more than one State at the same time?

[A] Yes, in up to 3 States with bilateral approval. [B] NO, dual registration is strictly prohibited by Article 18. [C] Yes, if operated under wet lease. [D] Only within EU Member States.

[*] OFFICIAL DEFINITION - Detailed Answer Explanation

CORRECT: [B]. Article 18 of the Chicago Convention explicitly prohibits dual registration.

Q2: Who allocates the series of nationality mark symbols used by States?

[A] ICAO [B] The International Telecommunication Union (ITU) [C] EASA [D] United Nations Security Council

[*] OFFICIAL DEFINITION - Detailed Answer Explanation

CORRECT: [B]. Nationality marks are selected from radio call sign series allocated by the ITU.

Q3: What is the minimum height of registration marks displayed on aeroplane wings?

[A] 15 cm [B] 30 cm (300 mm) [C] 50 cm [D] 60 cm

[*] OFFICIAL DEFINITION - Detailed Answer Explanation

CORRECT: [B]. Annex 7 specifies at least 30 cm for wings and fuselage of heavier-than-air aircraft (50 cm for airships/balloons).

Q4: Which of the following letter combinations is strictly prohibited in an aircraft registration mark?

[A] EC-ABC [B] G-PAN [C] D-AIBA [D] F-GLZK

[*] OFFICIAL DEFINITION - Detailed Answer Explanation

CORRECT: [B]. Combinations that can be confused with distress signals (PAN, SOS, XXX, TTT) or Q-codes (QAA-QNZ) are strictly prohibited.

Q5: Where must the fireproof aircraft identification plate be located?

[A] Inside the cockpit on the instrument panel [B] On the exterior near the main entrance [C] Inside the main landing gear bay [D] On the vertical fin next to the registration mark

[*] OFFICIAL DEFINITION - Detailed Answer Explanation

CORRECT: [B]. Under Annex 7, the identification plate must be secured in a prominent position near the main entrance.